

❶ Buy directly from the brand or authorised distributors. Avoid marketplace sellers whose identity you cannot verify.

❷ Check for third-party testing. Look for global standards such as Informed Sport, Informed Choice or NSF Certified for Sport.

❸ Scan the batch number and QR code. Genuine brands maintain batch test reports on their websites.

❹ Check for unrealistic claims. Products promising extreme fat loss, overnight muscle gain or steroid-like effects are usually unsafe.

❺ Look for clear manufacturer details. This includes address, customer support number, batch number, expiry date and FSSAI licence. Beyond individual responsibility, there is a broader structural reality in the supplement ecosystem that athletes, regulators and policymakers must acknowledge.

Most supplement companies primarily manufacture for recreational fitness consumers rather than elite athletes. In contrast, only a small number of athletes in each sport compete at the highest level, yet they operate under the most stringent anti-doping standards. Certifications such as Informed Sport or NSF Certified for Sport add significant testing and compliance costs, which are reflected in pricing. Accessing these certified products in India can further increase costs due to import duties and logistical challenges faced by athletes. Support from sports authorities, whether through partial subsidies for certification or tax-based incentives for manufacturers, could improve access to safer supplements and strengthen the ecosystem for clean sport in India.

Need for supplement discipline

A supplement is not a magic



solution. It is only a tool that supports training, recovery and nutrition. My work with elite athletes has shown that the safest performers are the ones who follow a disciplined, methodical approach. They track every product they use. They save empty boxes with batch numbers. They cross-check each ingredient against the WADA Prohibited List. They inform their coaches and nutritionists before adding anything new. They never borrow products from teammates. They keep their supplement routine simple and consistent.

Role of federations and coaches

Supplement safety is not the athlete's burden alone. Coaches must learn how to guide athletes towards certified products. Federations must educate players during camps and tournaments.

Parents of young athletes must understand that a cheaper online deal can put their child at risk. Sports institutions should encourage access to verified products through centralised procurement.

A matter of discipline: A supplement is only a tool that supports training, recovery and nutrition. Among elite athletes, the safest performers are the ones who follow a disciplined, methodical approach. GETTY IMAGES

My final message to athletes

I can say this with certainty: performance comes from discipline, not shortcuts. Supplements help only when chosen wisely and used correctly. Treat every supplement like an entry in your doping control log. Before it enters your body, check the label, the source and the batch report. Ask yourself whether you can defend this product in a doping hearing. If the answer is no, put it aside immediately. In sport, intentions do not matter when it comes to doping law. Only outcomes do. Your reputation and your future depend on your ability to make safe, informed and responsible choices. Clean sport begins with awareness. The more athletes invest in supplement education, the safer Indian sport becomes.